

THE MUGHAL DYNASTY

Babur to the Later Mughals • 1526 – 1748 AD

Babur → Humayun → Akbar → Jahangir → Shah Jahan → Aurangzeb → Decline | begins where the Delhi Sultanate ended

- Headings & Definitions
- Explanations
- Highlighter = Key Facts
- 🎯 Exam Tip
- ✗ Common Mistake
- 🧠 Memory Trick

StudyPlanner



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BABUR — FOUNDER OF THE MUGHAL DYNASTY (1526 – 1530)

Babur was a bright, studious boy from childhood. His original name was **Zahiruddin Muhammad Babur**, and he used the title **Padshah**.

- At the age of 12, he sat on the throne of **Farghana** (a region near Afghanistan) — but his own family members drove him out
- He arrived and settled in **Kabul in 1504**, from where he planned his attack on India

Babur's Four Battles

Battle	Year	Opponent
First Battle of Panipat	1526	Ibrahim Lodi
Battle of Khanwa	1527	Rana Sanga
Battle of Chanderi	1528	Medini Rai
Battle of Ghaghra	1529	Afghans

Panipat 1526



Khanwa 1527



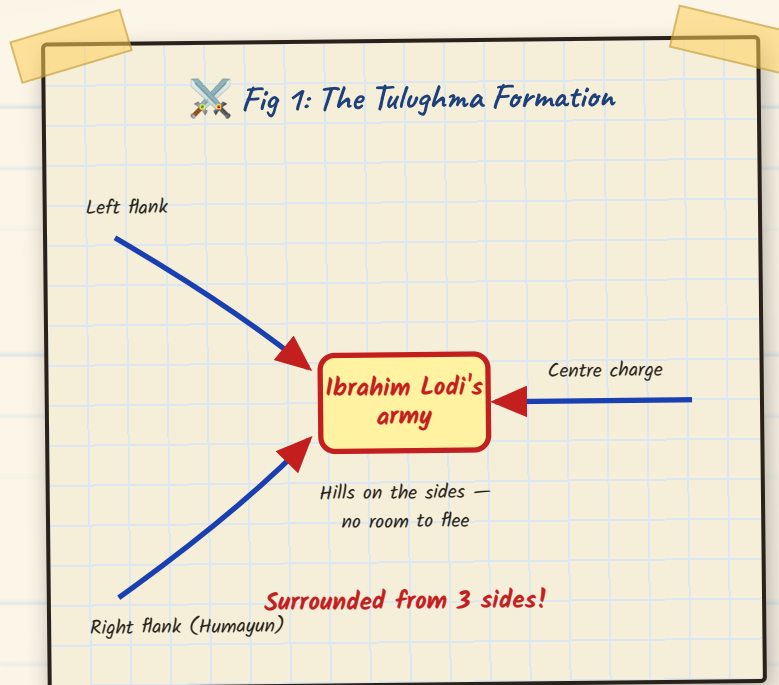
Chanderi 1528



Ghaghra 1529

The Tulughma Formation

In the First Battle of Panipat (1526), Babur used gunpowder on a large scale for the first time, along with his signature Tulughma formation.



How the Tulughma formation worked (tap to expand) ▼

Writings & Death

- Babur ruled from 1526 and died in 1530
- His autobiography, Tuzuk-i-Babari, was originally written in Turkish
- It was later translated into Persian as the Baburnama by Abdul Rahim Khan-i-Khana — one of Akbar's Navratnas (nine gems)
- Babur was first buried in Agra, and later re-buried in Kabul, Afghanistan

✗ Common Mistake

Don't say the Tuzuk-i-Babari was written in Persian — it was written in Turkish. The Baburnama is its Persian translation, done later by Abdul Rahim Khan-i-Khana.



Memory Trick

Babur's burial: Agra first, then Kabul. "A" before "K" — Agra before Kabul, just like the alphabet!

HUMAYUN + THE SHER SHAH SURI INTERLUDE

Humayun's First Reign (1530 – 1540)

Before becoming Sultan, Humayun managed the **Kandahar / Kabul** region. His brothers were less capable rulers.

Humayun vs Sher Shah Suri

Battle	Year	Winner
Battle of Chausa	1539 AD	Sher Shah Suri
Battle of Kannauj / Bilgram	1540 AD	Sher Shah Suri

Defeated and chased, Humayun fled and took refuge with the **Safavid Dynasty** in Iran.

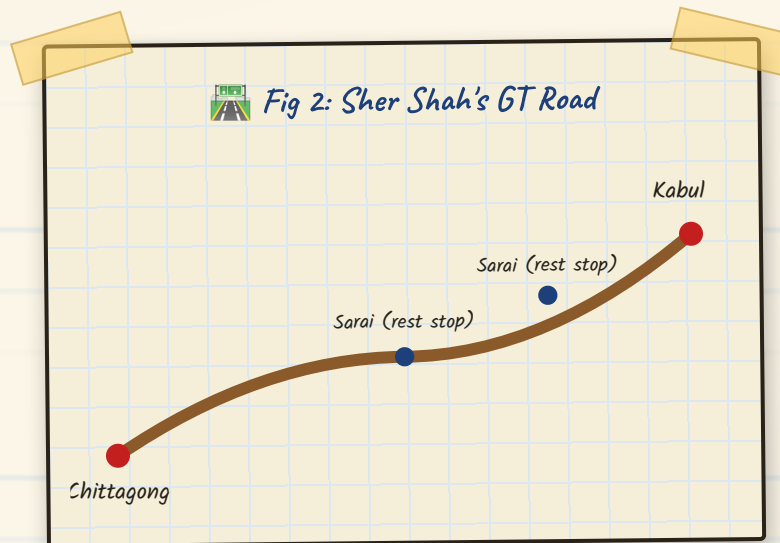
✗ Common Mistake

Don't confuse the **First Battle of Panipat (1526, Babur vs Ibrahim Lodi)** with the **Second Battle of Panipat (1556, Bairam Khan/Akbar vs Hemu)** — thirty years and a whole Sur interlude apart!

Sher Shah Suri (r. 1540 – 1545)

- Original name: **Farid Khan**; his father **Hasan Khan** was a Jagirdar in **Sasaram, Bihar**
- His administration was so strong that it was later adopted by Akbar
- Introduced the currency called the **Rupee**
- Built the **GT (Grand Trunk) Road** — from Chittagong (present-day Bangladesh) to Kabul (also recorded as up to Peshawar)
- Built **Sarais** (resting places) along the GT Road

- Issued **Patta** and **Qabuliyat** — agreements between the state and peasants fixing land revenue



Understand it like this...

Patta & Qabuliyat fixed exactly how much land revenue a peasant owed. This same idea of a **fixed, assessed revenue** later inspired Akbar's **Dahsala (10-year) system** under Todar Mal.

Sher Shah's Death (1545)

While attacking the strong walls of **Kalinjar fort** in 1545, a bomb he was using to break the wall exploded near his own feet. He remained alive for a couple of days before dying. He is buried in **Sasaram, Bihar**.



If this accident hadn't happened at Kalinjar, the Mughal dynasty might not have continued in India at all — it could have ended with Humayun!

Humayun Returns & the Second Battle of Panipat

- Humayun's biography, the **Humayun Nama**, was written by his sister **Gulbadan Begum**
- **Humayun's Tomb** in Delhi was commissioned by his wife **Haji Begum** (Bega Begum)
- Humayun regained the throne in **1555** but died in **1556**, from a fall down the library stairs — buried in **Delhi**
- 13-year-old **Akbar** succeeded him, with **Bairam Khan** as regent

- Since Sher Shah's Afghans were also weakened, a fresh contest followed: **Bairam Khan (for Akbar) vs Hemu (Hemchandra Vikramaditya)** — the **Second Battle of Panipat, 1556**
- Akbar's side won; he was crowned at age 13 at **Kalanaur, Punjab**

Exam Tip

Humayun's reign has **two parts**: 1530–1540 (before exile) and 1555–1556 (after regaining the throne). In between, it was the Sur Dynasty of Sher Shah Suri.

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AKBAR (1556 – 1605) — RAJPUTS, REVENUE + RANKS

Akbar's original name was **Jalaluddin Muhammad Akbar**.

Rajput Policy

- Akbar brought most Rajputs under control through **marriage alliances** or by giving them **high administrative posts**
- He married **Harka Bai** (later known as **Jodha Bai**), daughter of **Bharmal**, the **Kachhwaha Rajput ruler of Amer**
- Harka Bai was given the title **Maryam-uz-Zamani**; her son was **Jahangir**
- One Rajput ruler refused to accept Akbar's suzerainty: **Rana Sanga** of the **Sisodia clan** (whom Babur had earlier defeated at **Khanwa**)

Common Mistake

The **Battle of Haldighati (1576)** was fought against **Maharana Pratap**, grandson of **Rana Sanga** — not against Akbar personally. Akbar's forces were led by **Man Singh**; the result was **not a decisive victory** for either side, and historians hold differing views.

 Maharana Pratap never surrendered — he kept retreating and living in hiding while rebuilding his forces, effectively escaping Akbar's forces without a clear decisive outcome

at Haldighati.

Land Revenue: The Dahsala (Zabti) System

Introduced by Akbar's finance minister and Navratna, **Todar Mal**. Land revenue was assessed on a 10-year average basis.

Land Type	Description
Polaj	Never left fallow — most fertile
Parauti	Left fallow for 1-2 years
Chachar	Left fallow for 3-4 years
Banjar	Completely barren — no cultivation possible

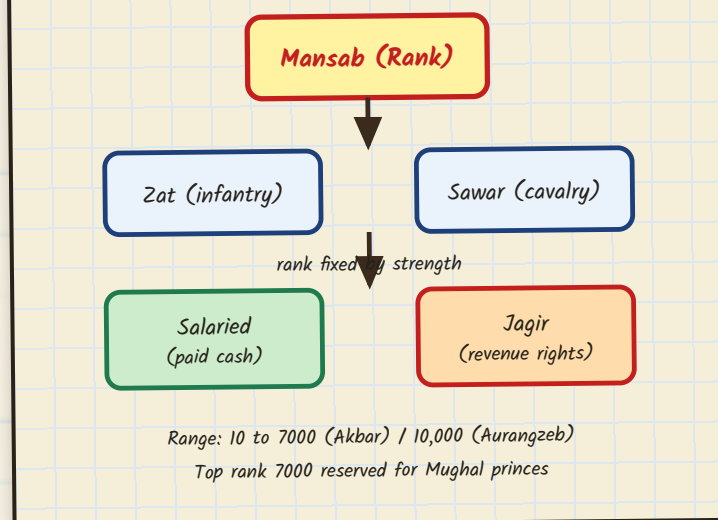
Memory Trick

Polaj → Parauti → Chachar → Banjar = fertile going down to barren, in that exact order.

The Mansabdari System (1571)

Mansab means rank. Ranks were allotted based on how much military force a noble maintained.

 Fig 3: How the Mansabdari System Worked



- **Zat** = infantry maintained; **Sawar** = horsemen/cavalry maintained

- Based on this, a noble was either **paid a salary** or given **full revenue rights** (a **jagir**) — making him both a mansabdar and a jagirdar
- Ranks ranged from 10 up to **7000** during Akbar's reign (later up to **10,000** under Aurangzeb)
- The top rank of 7000 was normally reserved for **Mughal princes**
- **Raja Man Singh** was given a mansab of 7000 — he was called **Saptahazari**

Exam Tip

Mansabdari (1571) is very close in date to Fatehpur Sikri (1570) — examiners often pair these two years together!

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AKBAR — RELIGION, LEARNING + ARCHITECTURE *Din-i-Ilahi*

Din-i-Ilahi was a new religion — a blend of the best elements from all religions. **Birbal** was the only courtier who accepted it; overall, the religion never gained wide popularity.

Common Mistake

Din-i-Ilahi was **not** a popular or widely-adopted faith — remember that **only Birbal** among Akbar's courtiers accepted it.

Ibadat Khana & Maktab Khana

- **Ibadat Khana** — the hall where religious discourses/discussions took place
- **Maktab Khana** — the translation department
- **Ramayana** translated into Persian by **Abdul Qadir Badauni**
- **Mahabharata** translated into Persian by **Badauni and Faizi**, titled **Razmnama**

Exam Tip

Don't mix up **Ibadat Khana** (religious discussion hall) with **Maktab Khana** (translation department) — different buildings, different purposes!

Akbarnama & Ain-i-Akbari

Written by **Abul Fazl** (a Navratna), the **Akbarnama** has three volumes:

1. Akbar's ancestors
2. Akbar's reign / tenure
3. Akbar's administration — known separately as the **Ain-i-Akbari**

Architecture

- Built **Fatehpur Sikri** in **1570**, in memory of Sheikh **Salim Chishti**, who blessed Akbar with a son (**Jahangir**)
- Built the **Buland Darwaza** at Fatehpur Sikri in **1575**, to commemorate his victory in **Gujarat**
- Built the **Panch Mahal** (at Fatehpur Sikri) and the **Agra Fort**
- Capital shifts: **Agra** → **Fatehpur Sikri (1571)** → **Lahore (1585)** → **back to Agra (1598)**

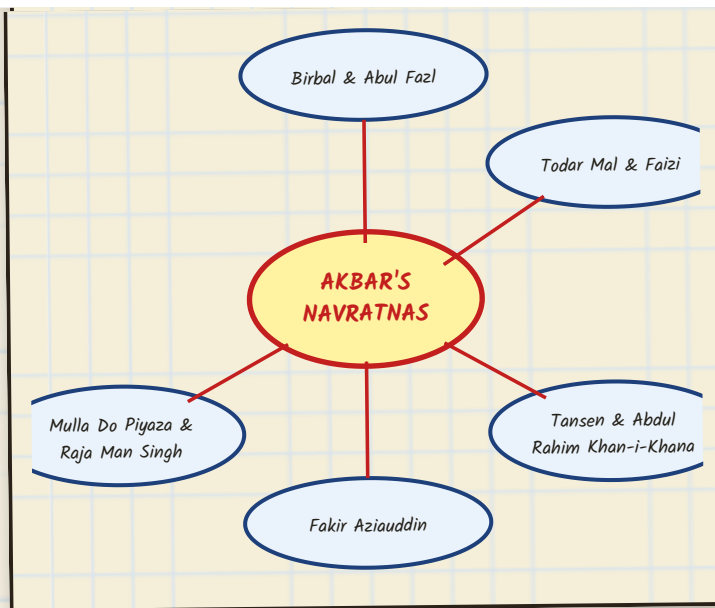


Memory Trick

"Fat Man" — **Fatehpur Sikri** built in **1570**, **Mansabdari** system introduced in **1571**. Two big Akbar events, one year apart!



Fig 4: Akbar's Navratnas (Nine Gems)



 Tansen – quick backstory (tap to expand) ▼

Akbar's last military expedition was to **Khandesh** (part of Ahmednagar, South India) in **1601**, which he captured — but he had to turn back when **Jahangir revolted** against him. Akbar died and was buried in **Agra**.

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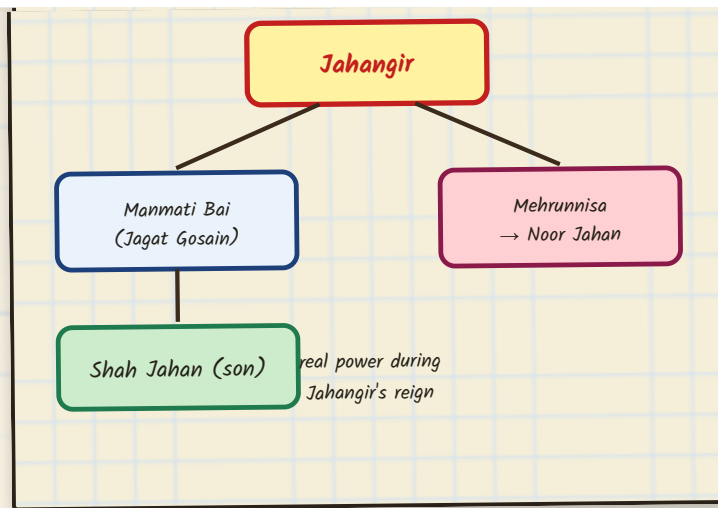
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JAHANGIR (1605 – 1627)

Jahangir's original name was **Nuruddin Muhammad Salim**, also known as **Prince Salim**.

 Fig 5: Jahangir's Family & Succession



- Jahangir struggled with **addiction**, and did little beyond his marriages
- His wife **Manmati Bai**, also known as **Jagat Gosain**, was the mother of **Shah Jahan**
- He later married **Mehrunnisa** — after defeating an Afghan in Bihar — who was given the title **Noor Jahan**



Real Power

Because of Jahangir's addiction, actual administrative control fell largely into **Noor Jahan's** hands.

Noor Jahan's Buildings (in Lahore)

- **Tomb of Itmad-ud-Daula** (built in memory of her father)
- **Noor Mahal**

Jahangir himself is credited with building the **Moti Masjid in Lahore** (one of three Moti Masjids in Mughal architecture — see Shah Jahan's page).

✗ Common Mistake

Shah Jahan was **not** born to Noor Jahan — his mother was Jahangir's earlier wife, **Manmati Bai (Jagat Gosain)**.

🧠 Memory Trick

Jahangir's birth name had "Salim" in it — think "Prince Salim" as his personal/pre-throne identity, just like Akbar was "Jalaluddin" before his title.

SHAH JAHAN (1628 – 1658)

Shah Jahan's original name was **Prince Khurram**, born to **Manmati Bai** (not Noor Jahan).

- **Mahabat Khan**, Jahangir's military commander, along with Shah Jahan, extended Mughal control in South India, capturing Ahmednagar and other territories
- Mahabat Khan grew irritated with Noor Jahan's influence and revolted against Jahangir
- ★ ● After Jahangir's death, **Shah Jahan and Mahabat Khan together removed Noor Jahan from power**

The Taj Mahal

Shah Jahan's wife, **Mumtaz Mahal**, died in **1631**, just three years into his reign. He built the **Taj Mahal** in Agra in her memory.



Fig 6: The Taj Mahal – Key Facts

Architect:
Ustad Ahmad Lahori

Pietra Dura
inlay work

Built for Mumtaz Mahal (d. 1631)

✗ Common Mistake

Don't confuse **Ustad Ahmad Lahori** (the architect who built the Taj Mahal) with **Abdul Hamid Lahori** (who wrote the *Badshahnama*, Shah Jahan's official biography) — very similar names, very different jobs!

Other Buildings & Features

- **Moti Masjid, Agra** — one of three Moti Masjids: **Lahore (Jahangir)**, **Agra (Shah Jahan)**, **Delhi (Aurangzeb)**
- **Diwan-i-Aam** (Hall of Public Audience) and **Diwan-i-Khas** (Hall of Private Audience) in his forts
- **The Peacock Throne**, embedded with the **Kohinoor diamond**, used over 1,000 kg of gold
- **Sheesh Mahal** — a palace decorated with glass/mirror work
- **Pietra Dura** — an inlay-art style using precious/semi-precious stones, seen at the Taj Mahal

Memory Trick

Bernier wrote "*Travels in the Mogul Empire*"; Tavernier wrote "*Travels in India*" — both French travellers at Shah Jahan's court.

War of Succession (1658)

Shah Jahan wanted his eldest son, **Dara Shikoh**, to succeed him. But Dara Shikoh, being of a gentler temperament, was defeated by his brother **Aurangzeb**.

✂ The succession battles (tap to expand) ▼

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AURANGZEB (1658 - 1707)

Aurangzeb took the title **Alamgir**, and was also given the title **Zinda Pir** ("Living Saint").

Religious Policy

- A devout Muslim, he appointed **Muhtasibs** — officials who checked whether people were following Islamic religious codes
- Issued the **Fatwa-i-Alamgiri**, a compilation of Islamic laws for all to follow
- Forced religious conversions, including on **Kashmiri Pandits**, who resisted
- When **Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji** refused to convert and support forced conversion, Aurangzeb had him executed

✗ Common Mistake

Alamgir and **Zinda Pir** are two separate titles of Aurangzeb — don't treat them as the same word or mix up which one means "world-seizer" (Alamgir) versus "living saint" (Zinda Pir).

Completing the Deccan Conquest

With Ahmednagar, Berar, and Bidar already captured earlier, Aurangzeb captured **Bijapur** in 1686 and **Golconda** in 1687.

Conflict with the Marathas



Fig 7: Aurangzeb vs the Marathas – Timeline

- 1659: Battle of Pratapgad — Shivaji kills Afzal Khan
- 1664: Shivaji defeats Shaista Khan
- 1665: Treaty of Purandar — 23 of 35 forts surrendered
- 1674: Shivaji crowned Chhatrapati at Raigad
- Later: Sambhaji resists, executed by Aurangzeb



Memory Trick

Marathas' two revenue tools: **Chauth** (1/4th of revenue) + **Sardeshmukhi** (extra levy)
— guerrilla raids funded by both.

Shivaji's son **Sambhaji** also refused to accept Mughal suzerainty; when eventually captured, Aurangzeb had him put to death in a brutal manner.

Decline & Death

- Aurangzeb spent his last 20+ years camped in the Deccan (Aurangabad, today's **Sambhaji Nagar**), never returning to Delhi — this marks the **beginning of Mughal decline**
- Died in 1707, buried in Aurangabad (Sambhaji Nagar)
- Built the **Moti Masjid** in Delhi
- His son **Azam Shah** built **Bibi Ka Maqbara** (called the "Mini Taj Mahal") in memory of his mother, **Dilras Banu Begum** (also known as **Rabia Durrani**)



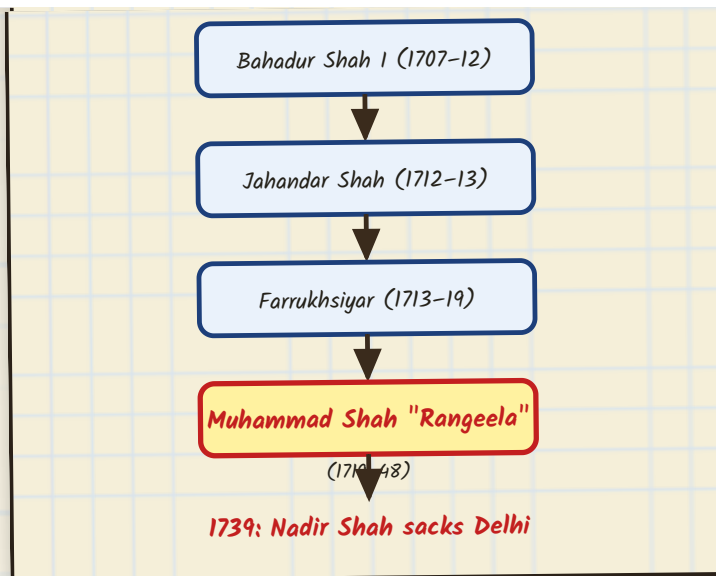
Exam Tip

Aurangzeb himself admitted his biggest mistake was leaving Delhi for the Deccan — the Marathas never fully submitted, and the empire weakened at its core while he was away.

THE LATER MUGHALS + DECLINE



Fig 8: Later Mughal Succession



- **Bahadur Shah I** (1707-1712), also known as **Shah Alam I**, ascended the throne with the help of **Zulfiqar Khan**
- **Jahandar Shah** ruled for just one year (1712-1713)
- **Farrukhsiyar** (1713-1719) ascended with the help of the **Sayyid Brothers** (Hussain Ali Khan Barha & Abdullah Khan Barha) — known as "Kingmakers"
- Farrukhsiyar issued the **Golden Farman** to the British in **1717** (they had cured him of an illness)
- The Sayyid Brothers later had Farrukhsiyar killed

✗ Common Mistake

The **Sayyid Brothers** made Farrukhsiyar king and later killed him — don't assume they stayed in power forever. **Muhammad Shah** had them killed early in his own reign, before they could do the same to him.

Muhammad Shah "Rangeela" (1719 - 1748)

- His first major act was having the **Sayyid Brothers** killed
- Known as "**Rangeela**" for his colourful, pleasure-loving personality — more interested in enjoyment than governance
- During his reign, **Nadir Shah** invaded and plundered Delhi in **1739**, carrying off the **Peacock Throne** along with the **Kohinoor diamond** embedded in it



Memory Trick

"Rangeela" = colourful/pleasure-loving → neglect of administration → Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion happened right under his watch.

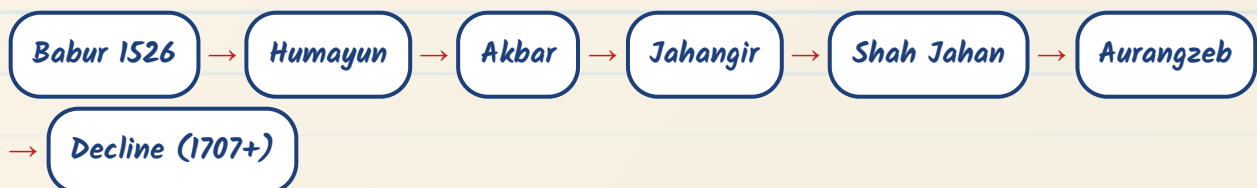
Mughal Architecture – One Last Note

The **Char Bagh** style of garden architecture (a four-quadrant garden layout) was developed by the Mughals — seen, for example, at **Humayun's Tomb**.

Exam Tip

Bibi Ka Maqbara ("Mini Taj Mahal," built by Azam Shah for his mother) is often confused with the Taj Mahal itself — remember it copies the Taj's design but is a separate, later monument.

★ Exam-Ready Summary – The Mughal Dynasty



- **Founded:** Babur, First Battle of Panipat, 1526 AD
- **Peak/expansion:** Akbar (Rajput alliances, Mansabdari, Dahsala) & Shah Jahan (architecture)
- **Religious extremism & overreach:** Aurangzeb
- **Turning point of decline:** Aurangzeb's prolonged Deccan campaign against the Marathas
- **Foreign humiliation:** Nadir Shah's sack of Delhi, 1739, under Muhammad Shah "Rangeela"

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